

Decision Maker			
Your CPU	The right card for you	You can play	And how!
250 MHz to 500 MHz	nVidia Riva TNT, ATi Rage 128, Matrox G550, up to nVidia GeForce2MX 200 based video cards (up to Rs 1,750)	<i>Quake III Arena, Serious Sam Second Encounter, Need for Speed: Porsche Unleashed</i>	You will need to play at lower resolutions and colour depth
600 MHz to 800 MHz	nVidia's GeForce2MX 400, GeForce2 DDR, ATi Radeon VE based video cards (up to Rs 4,000)	<i>Serious Sam Second Edition, Jedi Knight II: Jedi Outcast, Need for Speed: Hot Pursuit 2</i>	800x600 should be an ideal screen resolution, do keep most of the visual effects off though
850 MHz to 1GHz	nVidia's GeForce3, GeForce4 MX 440, ATi's 7500, 8500 based video cards (up to Rs 9,000)	<i>Medal of Honor: Allied Assault, Serious Sam Second Encounter, Unreal Tournament 2003</i>	You can graduate to 1024x768 level with FSAA and anisotropic filtering set at low setting
1.1 GHz to 1.5 GHz	ATi's 7500, 8500, nVidia's GeForce4 MX 440, GeForce4 Ti 4200 based cards (up to Rs 12,000)	<i>Medal of Honor: Allied Assault, Serious Sam Second Encounter, Unreal Tournament 2003, Unreal 2</i>	Play at 1024x768 with texture details set to high and FSAA and anisotropic filtering set to mid-levels
1.6 GHz to 2 GHz	ATi's 8500, nVidia's GeForce4 Ti4200, GeForce4 MX 440-8X based video cards (up to Rs 12,000)	<i>Medal of Honor: Allied Assault, Serious Sam Second Encounter, Unreal Tournament 2003, Unreal 2</i>	With at least 256MB of DDR RAM in tow, a smooth gaming experience awaits you at 1024x768
2.2 GHz and above	ATi 9700, GeForce4 Ti 4800 based video cards (up to Rs 19,000)	Almost any game	Enjoy a game at the highest level of visual detail

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to its poor showing. It was often bested by older technology—the MSI GeForce4MX 440 card beat it under *Serious Sam* with scores of 63.5 fps and 54.9 fps, while the Parhelia posted 48.4 fps and 35.7 fps at 1024x768 and 1280x1024, respectively. As is evident, it also failed to cross the 60 fps mark in *Serious Sam* and managed to just achieve that goal under *UT 2003* with 60.66 fps at 1024x768. This would not be a bad showing at all if it wasn't for the price tag of Rs 30,000. As it stands, we can only recommend this card for those few of you who wish to work and play with three monitors simultaneously.

Our recommended solution: Creative 3DBlaster5 RX 9000 Pro.

What it all leads to

That the consumer video card market is split unevenly between nVidia and ATi solutions was apparent from this comparison test. The entry-level cards are currently based on nVidia's Rage and GeForce2MX chipsets, but these will soon be pushed out of contention by their older GeForce4MX brethren. As they should be: the ENNYAH RAGE 128 PLUS failed to show textures for 3DMark2001 SE; under *UT 2003*, it showed corrupt textures for the low resolutions and failed to run the high resolutions altogether. Clearly, age is visible.

While a GeForce2MX-based card can still be a cheap buy, it would soon grow long in the tooth as is showcased by the Max-force GeForce2MX 200, a card that refused to touch 30 fps in *UT 2003*. Solutions from Trident and Matrox also failed to impress. While the Trident T64 costs the least at Rs 1,375, it brings with it texture corruption galore in tests that show future-readiness (3DMark2001 SE and *UT 2003*), while failing to perform to any acceptable level in all tests but the low resolution one under *Quake III Arena* (where it scored a decent 53.4 fps at 640x480). The Matrox cards are too costly for the application areas under which they fall, thanks both to technology and performance. The Millenium G550 at Rs 8,000 is in no way a casual gaming solution.